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Analysing the SC's judgment on sex work

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For more than three decades, sex workers have told governments and courts how anti-trafficking interventions cause profound harm including forced rescues, indefinite detention in "corrective homes", separation from children and even threat to life. And for decades, these accounts were only acknowledged in fragments, and never in a comprehensive rights-based framework. That is what makes the Supreme Court's judgment of May 29, 2026, so significant.

Across nearly 300 pages, the court departs from many assumptions that have long shaped anti-trafficking discourse globally. It recognises that agency and vulnerability can coexist; rejects the conflation of migration with trafficking; affirms that constitutional rights do not disappear because society disapproves of sex work; holds that consenting adult sex workers cannot forcibly be rescued; and that any intervention must begin with an inquiry into consent.

Invoking Article 142, the court gives these directions legal force.

But the judgment also exposes a paradox: it adopts arguments that have been painstakingly developed by sex workers but does not acknowledge the workers or their collectives (such as the National Network of Sex Workers among others). This is not only a question of credit; it reveals how even progressive jurisprudence can reproduce a hierarchy of knowledge in which those most affected by law remain its least recognised authors.

What the judgment assumes
The judgment places faith in institutions that have repeatedly failed the very people it seeks to protect. The court assumes that clearer legal standards will produce different institutional behaviour – that police officers will assess consent without prejudice, magistrates will suspend moral judgment, shelter homes will become rights-based



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Sex workers and their unions must move from the margins to the centre of implementation. They should draft guidelines, monitor compliance, shape police training, and establish standards for shelters

support services, and sex workers will have access to legal aid.

For many women, especially those from the Dalit and Adivasi communities, bureaucracy has never been a neutral system. Caste discrimination and economic marginalisation continue to shape everyday encounters with the state. One woman, wrongly labelled a trafficker after a raid, has spent seven years reporting every month to a police station while attending court hearings where, despite all this time, her statement has never even been recorded. "I go to court and sit outside. Then they call my name, and I go inside. But they don't ask me anything. They have not even recorded my statement yet!"

The top court rightly recognises caste as one of the structural conditions that can push women into sex work. But it stops there. Caste does not simply explain entry into the profession. It also structures every institution responsible for implementing this judgment. As one worker put it: "The state says that *ache din* (good days) will come. When will our *ache din* come? Everything is about money these days. Take any actor. They can kill but do not get arrested. Those who do not have money have to keep going to the court like me." Her question exposes the judgment's central assumption: that the law is applied equally once rights are recognised. For many workers, the challenge is not only overcoming moral prejudice. It is navigating a legal and bureaucratic system that continues to be shaped by caste.

The judgment is also noticeably quieter about another source of violence: the anti-trafficking industry itself. The court recommends reforming shelter homes but does not examine the organisations that run them, the funding structures that sustain them, or the incentives that make carceral and forced rescue practices persist. The rescue industry is not solely a humanitarian project. It is sustained by a dense network of

civil society organisations that participate in forced raids, manage shelter homes, and exercise significant authority over the women confined within them.

One woman who experienced both prison and a government shelter offered a striking comparison. "Even after rescue, we are bound by the shelter. It is another form of bondage. It seems better to serve six months in jail and come out free than to stay in a shelter for an unknown time." This account is not an exception. It exposes an uncomfortable reality that anti-trafficking discourse obscures: rescue can become another mechanism of control.

The road ahead

The top Court's recommendations are important. But for the judgment to fulfil its promise, three priorities stand out.

First, sex workers and their unions must move from the margins to the centre of implementation. They should draft guidelines, monitor compliance, shape police training, and establish standards for shelters. Second, the anti-trafficking NGO sector deserves scrutiny. Longstanding evidence suggests that some have become active participants in coercive rescue practices while operating with limited accountability to the communities they claim to serve. Their funding and legal immunity should no longer be taken for granted.

Finally, the structural conditions identified by the court do not require new institutions to fix. India already possesses an extensive welfare architecture. The challenge is ensuring that sex workers can access it as rights-bearing citizens.

The Supreme Court has opened an important constitutional door. Whether it leads to meaningful change will depend on whether India's institutions can abandon decades of paternalism and begin treating sex workers as citizens whose choices deserve the same legal respect as anyone else's.

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Supreme Court has recognised sex work as a “profession” and observed that its practitioners are entitled to dignity and equal protection under law.

Article 21 declares that no person shall be deprived of his life or personal liberty except according to procedure established by law. This right is available to both citizens and non-citizens.

Sex workers should not be “arrested or penalised or harassed or victimised” whenever there is a raid on any brothel, “since voluntary sex work is not illegal and only running the brothel is unlawful”.

Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, 1956 (ITPA):

Does not criminalise sex work per se, but penalises brothel-keeping, soliciting, and living off earnings of sex work

India Produces smart scientists but is struggling to retain them

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Research flourishes when ideas compete but suffers when people compete for proximity to power; many of India's laboratories continue to operate within rigid hierarchies that would appear strange in leading scientific institutions elsewhere in the world

Rishi Dharmapalan

Recent reports of nearly 120 scientists resigning from the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) have rightly raised concerns. The ISRO has been a symbol of India's scientific aspirations and such an exodus cannot be dismissed as an ordinary episode of employee turnover. Resignations have occurred over the years but the scale of recent departures confronts us with the question of why some of India's brightest scientific minds are electing to leave institutions millions dream of joining.

The phenomenon is not unique to ISRO. Similar stories have emerged from laboratories under the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), premier autonomous institutes, and several government-funded research organisations. Often these departures are hard to notice as part of a larger pattern because they occur one scientist at a time – yet together they point to a deeper issue deserving of national attention.

Real main reason

The most obvious explanation is salary but it is not sufficient. Scientists who have spent decades building their expertise and reputation rarely leave only because another organisation is offering a bigger paycheck. Many of those that are resigning are also in the latter half of their careers, and generally unwilling to risk financial and professional stability. Yet, that they want is something even greater: professional dignity, freedom of thought, and the freedom to work on their topics of choice.

Several researchers – many of whom are unwilling to go on record for fear of repercussions – in private characterise these institutions as places where bureaucratic power is increasing at the expense of that of science, and where it is becoming more risky to question authority. The tragedy is that while Indian science inherited world-class institutions, it also retained a colonial administrative mindset.

Research flourishes when ideas compete but suffers when people compete for proximity to power. Many of India's laboratories continue to operate within rigid hierarchies that would appear strange in leading scientific institutions elsewhere in the world. Young scientists often learn quickly that survival depends less on understanding invisible administrative boundaries. In some institutions, even simple acts of professional equality are viewed as breaches of etiquette. Respect, instead of being earned through scholarship and mentorship, is demanded through designation.

A class system

In order to be creative, for example, a doctoral student should be able to



Representative image of the National Institute of Animal Biotechnology (NIAB) in Hyderabad. India is spending a historically unprecedented, but otherwise still insufficient, amount of money on scientific research. [NLS 2023](#)

challenge a senior scientist's hypothesis without fearing that his or her long-term career will be adversely affected. A young investigator should feel confident enough to question established ideas. The world's best research environments are the best because they allow just such interactions.

Attend an international scientific conference in Europe or the Americas and you will often witness something remarkably ordinary: Nobel laureates standing in the same cafeteria queue as graduate students, and young scholars openly questioning senior scientists during presentations. They are respectful – and the seniors know that – but that respect flows from intellectual contributions rather than via ceremonial protocols.

However, many Indian scientific gatherings continue to have a bureaucratic rather than academic culture. Designated speakers receive VIP badges, exclusive dining arrangements, and special hospitality while students and junior participants are treated as an entirely different class. Such symbolism is not harmless. It reinforces a hierarchy that has little place in science. Science has never progressed because someone occupied a larger office or enjoyed a separate lunch. Let us foster the many little interactions; they could make a big difference.

Speaking up Equally worryingly, scientists rarely speak openly about unhealthy workplace cultures because the ecosystem is remarkably small. Today's reviewer may become tomorrow's selection committee member. Today's director may influence tomorrow's funding decision.

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Occasionally, some disturbing information emerges, including allegations of harassment, vindictive administrative actions, and attempts to publicly discredit accomplished scientists. Whether every allegation withstands scrutiny is for due process to determine – but the recurring perception is immediately damaging.

As a result, many talented researchers are now moving to private research organisations, emerging deep-tech companies, universities abroad, and/or international collaborations where scientific autonomy has more room than administrative structures. India's growing innovation ecosystem benefits from this movement to some extent but it is not a zero-sum: our national laboratories lose institutional memory and experienced mentors.

India is spending a historically unprecedented, but otherwise still insufficient, amount of money on scientific research. Excellent skills are new needed for new research missions, including those involving semiconductors, quantum technologies, artificial intelligence, biotechnology, and spaceflight. But newer buildings can be built in a few months and, with adequate funds, sophisticated instruments can be bought, building an environment that

builds great scientists is a very long process, often taking decades.

Conscious effort Today, India must increase administrative transparency in scientific institutions, and install robust systems to redress grievances concerning workplace harassment and mentoring-based leadership training to ensure a leadership free from command.

In parallel, we need a conscious effort to break free of the colonial bureaucracy that remains in the daily life of institutions. Respect should not disappear from scientific workplaces but it differs fundamentally from unquestioned deference.

India has repeatedly demonstrated that its scientists possess extraordinary capability: the achievement of space exploration, vaccines, supercomputing, pharmaceuticals, biotechnology, and engineering stand as testimony to that talent. The challenge today is not in producing brilliant scientists – our universities and institutions have figured that out. The challenge is to ensure those scientists can still flourish after they enter India's laboratories.

If we fail to reform workplace culture, the next generation may simply know our public institutions. That will be an immeasurable loss. Science thrives advanced through ideas that challenged power – not by power that that silences people or ideas.

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THE GIST

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India Produces Smart scientists but is struggling to retain them

Brain Drain refers to the emigration of highly skilled and educated individuals from one country to another, usually in search of better opportunities.

In India engineers, doctors, scientists, IT professionals, and academics move to developed countries like the USA, UK, Canada, and Australia.

Between 2015 and 2022, 1.3 million Indians left the country, many of whom were highly educated professionals.

Top Destinations: The United States, Canada, and Europe remain top destinations for these skilled workers.

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Why

Colonial Administrative Mindset: Research institutions often operate with rigid bureaucratic oversight where administrative authority overrides scientific merit and questioning leadership carries professional risks.

Hierarchical Workplace Culture: Respect is frequently demanded via official designations rather than earned through scientific mentorship and scholarship. Junior scientists and graduate students are often discouraged from challenging established hypotheses.

Institutional Symbolism and Class Division: Academic conferences and lab environments frequently reinforce class divides through VIP arrangements, badges, and separate dining facilities rather than fostering egalitarian scientific discourse.

Lack of Open Grievance Redressal: Small, interconnected scientific ecosystems make researchers hesitant to voice workplace concerns, fearing repercussions on peer reviews, committee selections, or future funding approvals.

Pull of External Opportunities: Experienced researchers are increasingly drawn toward private research organizations, deep-tech startups, global industry roles, and international research universities offering superior intellectual autonomy.

India Produces Smart scientists but is struggling to retain them

Impact of Losing Senior Talent:

Loss of Institutional Memory: Frequent resignations by experienced project leads erode decades of specialized domain knowledge required for complex national missions.

Disruption to Mentorship Pipelines: Senior researchers serve as essential mentors for early-career scientists; their departure weakens training for the next generation.

Risks to High-Stakes National Projects: Unplanned departures create short-term operational vulnerabilities in strategic sectors like spaceflight, quantum computing, AI, and semiconductors.

For doxxing victims in India, a patchwork of laws to navigate

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Vincent Bhalla
New Delhi, August 2

WOMEN WHO participated in the protests at Delhi's Jantar Mantar are finding themselves at the centre of an online backlash.

Social media accounts have shared videos and photographs of a number of such women at the protests, and made public their personal details, such as phone numbers and home addresses. This has resulted in instances of harassment, including rape and death threats.

The act of publicly revealing private personal information to intimidate or shame someone is known as doxxing. Despite its severe real-world consequences, doxxing is not explicitly defined or penalised as a criminal offence under Indian law. Legal experts say that victims have to navigate a patchwork of existing statutes under the Information Privacy Statute (2008) and the Information Technology (IT) Act to find recourse.

Laws in India

The issue must be viewed in two parts, Supreme Court Justice Abhay Manohar Sapre told *The Indian Express*, emphasising that of personal information, and subsequent threats or harassment based on that information. The latter is easier to prosecute under Indian law.

If doxxing leads to someone monitoring a woman's internet use or trying to contact her repeatedly, it amounts to a breach of the IT Act, which deals with stalking. Rape and death threats fall under Section 354 of the IPC, which deals with criminal intimidation. If the victim is a minor, Section 23 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act is invoked.

Supreme Court Justice Dhananjaya Kumar said that if the doxxing involves the public display of pictures that has vilified a woman, it could trigger Section 29 of the IT Act, which prohibits acts "intended to insult the modesty of a woman" and those that "violate upon the privacy of... a woman". If the published content one's reputation, provisions for criminal defamation can be invoked, he added.

However, when it comes to the mere publication of personal data, the law is unclear. Previous judgments said that the act of doxxing itself is largely treated as a civil offence under the IT Act, rather than a criminal offence.

Section 66D of the IT Act criminalises the capturing or publishing of images of private body parts without consent. For general personal data, victims have to rely on Section 72A of the IT Act, which provides that unauthorised disclosure of "personal" data is a civil offence. It also tentatively provides for a financial penalty of up to Rs 5 lakh, making it a civil wrong rather than a criminal offence.

Platform accountability

Victims can also hold social media platforms accountable. Under the IT Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code Rules, 2021, platforms are legally obligated to make reasonable efforts to prevent users from disclosing information "in breach of another's privacy, including identity, partner, child and other details".

The Rules mandate strict timelines for platforms to act. Intermediaries are required to acknowledge complaints within 24 hours and resolve them within 90 days. For content, platforms regarding content that falls under specific severe categories—such as privacy violations or harassment—must resolve the issue within 48 hours.

If platforms fail to comply with these rules or specifications, they could be held liable for the content. In practice, however, a legal immunity that shields tech companies from being prosecuted for what users post on their sites. In practice, however, different platforms or content have varying levels of response. Some may delete content. Twitter's Moderation, Anti-Spam and Policy Management and Global Transparency Policy Lead at Access Now, an international digital rights organisation, told *The Indian Express*.

For immediate relief, lawyers advise victims to preserve all evidence, including screenshots and URLs of the abusive posts.

For doxxing victims in India, a patchwork of laws to navigate

Doxxing refers to the act of publicly revealing someone's private personal information to intimidate or shame them.

India does not have a dedicated law framework to prevent doxxing

Why are people turning to social media for childbirth advice

Why are people turning to social media for childbirth advice?

Social media platforms are monetising unscientific content promoting home births and free births without doctors; while many parents turn to these practices after traumatic hospital experiences, experts warn that unsafe online advice and lack of regulation can have fatal consequences

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far:

In late June, a Tamil Nadu woman, 32, died from a postpartum haemorrhage and other complications. According to the police, the woman died after a medically assisted birth at home, where family members allegedly helped her by watching YouTube videos for guidance. She leaves behind both her newborn and an older daughter. According to the initial police reports, the couple had wanted a “natural delivery.”

Around the world, more people who want to give birth at home or without doctors and surgeries are going to Reddit, Instagram, and YouTube to both give and get medical guidance. This unvetted, high-risk content could cost the lives of more parents and newborns.

Is social media promoting childbirth without doctors?

Social media companies with millions of users – Google-owned YouTube and Meta-owned Instagram – are allowing content creators to share unscientific advice, as well as make money from videos that document and promote home births with only a midwife. On Reddit, most home birthing content is text-based but still poses risks.

For example, a home birth YouTube vlog posted in November 2025 with over 146,000 views showed the mother touting a “2-HOUR PAIN FREE HOME BIRTH” in a small pool, as well as promoting a religious birthing course and app. The mother said she gave birth at 42 weeks, and claimed she experienced a “healthy,

supernatural labor”. The vlog claimed that the midwife “finally got there only a few minutes before the baby’s arrival” and that the family waited 90 seconds for the newborn’s first breath, which is far longer than the accepted standard.

Another “natural home birth” vlog that was documenting the mother’s labour ended with an emergency hospital delivery after meconium (the baby’s very sticky first faeces) was detected before birth, upping the risk of potential infection should the baby inhale this via the amniotic fluid (meconium aspiration).

“Not the outcome we hoped for, but grateful to the NHS for keeping me and baby safe,” stated the description of the mother’s video from September that had over 420,000 views.

Multiple similar home birth vlogs contained links to online storefronts and other social media channels, or promoted products, coupon codes and affiliate links. This allows home birthers to directly profit from their content and view counts. But monetising childbirth vlogs brings up ethical concerns as birth videos include footage of the naked newborn and/or the mother in an undressed and vulnerable state.

On Instagram, several free birth influencers claim that they are going through their pregnancies without any doctors’ appointments or ultrasound scans.

Other free or home birthers on Instagram recommended extending pregnancies well beyond 41 weeks (to avoid being induced at a hospital), even though such delays without medical clearance can increase the chances of a stillborn baby. Free birth influencers and

even some midwives online share frightening anecdotes about patient abuse, and push the false idea that women’s bodies are made to birth babies without outside help.

In Reddit’s Home Birth community, forum rules ban medical advice. However, this rule is openly flouted as people often ask sensitive medical questions, with other users’ answers presented as opinions or personal stories.

One pregnant user in the Reddit Home Birth community, for example, posted that they had multiple high blood pressure readings. They dismissed these readings and declined a hospital-recommended induction. Instead, they asked Reddit users about taking a specific oil. This Reddit poster also minimised the potential risks of that oil causing the baby to pass faeces (meconium) before birth.

The work of free birth influencers online has already led to fatal consequences in the offline world. Take the Free Birth Society movement – with 72,000 subscribers on YouTube and 134,000 followers on Instagram – that has been named in relation to multiple baby injuries and deaths around the world, per an investigation by *The Guardian*. The founder has continued to promote highly unscientific videos, as well as her business, on social media.

Unlike the health content shared online during the COVID-19 pandemic that came with compulsory medical disclaimers, home birthing videos on YouTube and Instagram lack formal warnings about the dangers of giving birth in one’s house (home birth) or without doctors present (free birth).

Why do people choose home births or free births?

There are valid reasons why these practices still exist. Many pregnant women on forums such as Reddit have posted about traumatising birthing experiences at hospitals, such as being ignored or assaulted by healthcare professionals, being pressured into caesarean deliveries, having surgeons cut them without warning, not being given adequate pain relief, and having their bodies and babies handled roughly.

For their part, home birthers portray their deliveries as being quiet, peaceful, luxurious, and even spiritual. Edited vlogs and curated clips on social media show the birthing parents being cared for by their partners, midwives, and other children for hours on end. Many are seen seated in a pool of warm water while surrounded by soft lights, nature, prayers, soothing music, snacks, and even photographers. In multiple such videos, rushing to the hospital to be induced or undergo a C-section is often framed as a catastrophe to be avoided until the very last minute. But when such practices are normalised, hospital doctors and nurses face increased pressure; instead of a monitored delivery, they are dealing with a medical emergency.

In truth, the popularity of free birthing and home birthing can be seen as a response to the failure of hospitals to give pregnant parents the standard of care that they require. But as influencers leverage both trauma and technology in order to promote life-threatening birthing practices on social media, what viewers must really see is the dangerous absence of regulation.

Why has PoK erupted in protests

Why has PoK erupted in protests?

How did demands over prices evolve into a movement for greater political representation in PoK? How has Islamabad responded to the protests? What has India said about the unrest? How have international rights groups and overseas Kashmiris reacted to the crackdown?

EXPLAINER

Kallol Bhattacharjee

The story so far:

Simmering discontent over inflation, lack of accountability and opaque governance in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) has escalated into a violent crackdown by Pakistani security forces over the past week, leaving dozens dead and many more injured. Security forces have reportedly used assault weapons and sniper fire against protesters gathered in the main squares of cities such as Rawalakot and Muzaffargarh to oppose the three-phase election currently under way in PoK. The Jammu Kashmir Joint Awami Action Committee (JKJAAC), which has been leading the protests, claims that more than 50 people have been killed over the past week as demonstrations continue against what it alleges is a rigged election process.

Why are protests taking place in PoK? PoK is caught between an establishment-backed election and a popular political movement opposing the political basis of that election. The JKJAAC has been protesting peacefully in Rawalakot, Muzaffargarh, and other locations in the region seeking to build a more representative political system in PoK. The three-phase elections started on July 27 and will conclude on August 11.

The movement, which emerged after the COVID-19 pandemic to curb the prices of essential items, has evolved over the years into a protest against the lack of political representation for the local population in the PoK legislature. The legislature of PoK has a total of 53 seats, out of which 45 are elected, and eight are reserved for refugees of Indian Jammu and Kashmir who migrated after 1947. In elections for these 12 seats, refugee voters located outside PoK cast their ballots. Locals claim that the reserved seats



Supporters of the banned Joint Awami Action Committee, an alliance of civil society groups, start a fire to block a road during a protest in Muzaffargarh. REUTERS

reduce representation of communities from the region and allow Islamabad to override local concerns.

As the authorities proceeded with the election process without addressing the demand for removing the reserved seats, the JKJAAC called for a "long march". Though the authorities have responded with a harsh crackdown, the protesters have shown that they are not going away anytime soon as they have managed to sustain the protests for months. The protest received new momentum after a PhD scholar, Osama Jaleel, of Quaid-e-Azam University in Islamabad, was reportedly killed in police firing in Rawalakot. Before his death, Osama Jaleel had been noted on the Internet for his fiery speeches in the protest meetings in Rawalakot. The JKJAAC claims that a total of 86 persons have died in the security crackdown till July 31.

How is the political relation between Islamabad and PoK?

The federal government of Pakistan has had a complicated relationship with the region for years, as mainstream political parties such as the Pakistan Peoples Party and Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz have not been able to fulfil the developmental aspirations of the people of PoK. In recent days, however, the situation has worsened following comments by leading

figures within the establishment about the protesters. Pakistan Defence Minister Khwaja Asif incensed public sentiments by referring to the protesters as "enemies just like Indians". The main complaint is that the mainstream political parties in Islamabad have not met the region's developmental needs. Locals allege that they have been neglected by Islamabad, echoing many of the same complaints long voiced by residents of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan, where protests and insurgencies have continued for decades. The second phase of polling on August 2 drew allegations of irregularities and rigging.

What has India said about the Rawalakot protests?

Over the past few months, the Ministry of External Affairs has repeatedly condemned the use of harsh methods against protesters in Rawalakot and in other parts of PoK. On July 31, the Ministry of External Affairs blamed the 'Pakistani Establishment' and said: "This crackdown has resulted in the tragic death of over 40 civilians and serious injuries to many. Its absolute disdain for the innocent people of PoK was laid bare when their Defence Minister branded the protesting civilians as enemies." Adding to this, the Special Assistant to Prime Minister on Political Affairs openly

admitted that the very 'mujahideen' that the Pak establishment trained, armed and sent to bleed India have now turned their guns inward, weaponising themselves against the state.

Mirwaiz Dr. Umar Farooq has expressed "deep concern" over the unrest across the LoC and called for dialogue. "We are deeply anguished by the continuing unrest and tragic loss of precious lives during the past month and a half," said Umar Farooq. The JKJAAC has opposed India's remarks, and in a statement on June 24, the group said it "firmly rejects any attempt by India to interpret, appropriate, or project the current situation in Azad Jammu and Kashmir in support of its own claims or geopolitical positions. The present civil rights movement is neither a proxy nor an extension of interstate rivalries. Any such characterisation is both inaccurate and misleading."

Is there a strategic dimension?

The protests have been concentrated in Rawalakot, which lies along the Line of Control, and Pakistan's response so far shows it will not tolerate instability in a region of primary importance to its security.

The strategic dimension of the disturbances can be assessed by the fact that Kotli, Muzaffargarh and Rawalakot – the areas where protests have taken place – are the most terror-related targets that India had claimed to have hit in the May 2025 Operation Sindoor.

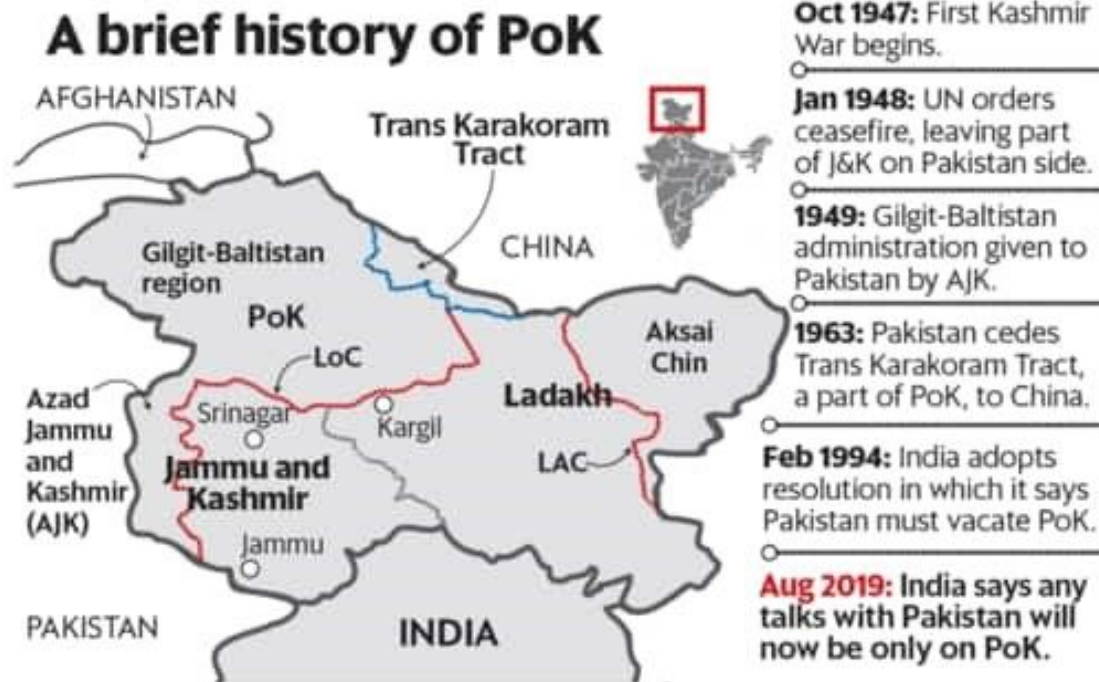
Apart from India, Amnesty International and influential leaders in the U.K. have also called for restraint from the Pakistani establishment. Responding to the existing communication blackout in PoK, Amnesty has said: "We urge the Pakistani authorities to restore all communications access and allow media and independent observers into the area." Non-resident Mirpur Kashmiris, who have a strong community-level presence in the U.K., have started an online campaign to restrain Pakistan's security establishment from continuing with the repressive measures.

THE GIST

▼ A movement that began over rising prices has evolved into a campaign against the PoK election process, with the JKJAAC demanding the removal of 12 reserved seats that it says undermine local representation.

▼ Protests have intensified amid allegations of election rigging and a deadly security crackdown; Pakistan's response has drawn criticism from India, Amnesty International and U.K.-based Kashmiri groups.

Why has PoK erupted in protests



Why lab grown diamonds are sustainable alternative to mined stones



GETTY IMAGES

Why lab-grown diamonds are sustainable alternative to mined stones

Natural diamond mining is facing dwindling supplies while remaining associated with environmental damage, forced labour, conflict and pollution. Lab-grown diamonds offer a more affordable, traceable and sustainable alternative, with India investing in indigenous production and research

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For centuries, diamonds have been regarded as symbols of eternal love, their rarity, stratification and hardness behind the glamour of these stones lies a cold, hard truth: an industry plagued by forced labour, child workers and pollution.

Some of the world's largest diamond mines, such as the Argyle mine in Australia and the black mine in Canada, have reached a point of exhaustion in recent years. This depletion has worsened year by year, and production is now at a multi-decade low. After all, natural diamond mines are only a finite source. It is estimated that the 40 diamond mines accounting for 95% of global production spread throughout Botswana, Russia and other countries have a lifespan of no more than 50 years.

The hidden cost

However, the problems associated with natural diamonds extend beyond dwindling supplies. Diamond mining requires large amounts of water and energy and causes considerable damage to the surrounding ecosystems. It is often associated with deforestation, displacement, soil erosion and water pollution. Massive open-pit excavations can also trigger landslides and mudslides.

Moreover, labourers suffer from a plethora of diseases as a result of working in diamond mines. A study by Gill Nelson et al. in 2011 found that workers are at a higher risk of asbestos exposure and may develop asbestos-related diseases, including asbestosis, pleural plaques, and mesothelioma.

Then come the blood diamonds, which are mined diamonds involved in illicit sales and used to fund military action. It is nearly impossible to deduce a diamond's

geographic origin. Although the Kimberly Process was introduced to verify that diamonds are conflict-free, regulatory gaps continue to allow blood diamonds to be smuggled across borders. As a result, these stones contribute to a political and civil conflict.

There, concern over an important question: can the beauty and durability of diamonds be preserved without the social and environmental costs of mining? In recent years, the answer appears to be yes, through the use of lab-grown diamonds.

A sustainable alternative emerges

The first proven synthetic diamonds were made by GE (General Electric) in 1954, under a process codenamed "Project Superpressure". They utilised the HPHT (High Pressure, High Temperature) process, which mimics the conditions under which natural diamonds form in the Earth's mantle.

In 1981, another method known as CVD (Chemical Vapour Deposition) was used. This involves depositing diamond material onto diamond seeds through chemical reactions involving carbon-rich gases.

Lab-grown diamonds are physically and optically identical to their natural counterparts. Until 2018, they were sold at a modest discount to mined diamonds. Due to improvements in the efficiency of laboratory equipment, the price of lab-grown diamonds has continued to decline over the years. Now, more affordable and traceable, lab-grown diamonds preserve the quality that has made diamonds desirable since time immemorial while avoiding much of the damage linked to conventional production.

India's push for lab-grown diamonds

India has also begun to recognise the potential of lab-grown diamonds as a sustainable and economically viable

alternative to mined stones. In the Union Budget 2022-23, the Government of India announced measures to encourage indigenous production of lab-grown diamonds, including support for research into HPHT and CVD technologies.

As part of this initiative, in 2023, the Indian Institute of Technology Madras (IIT Madras) was awarded a five-year grant of approximately ₹24 crore by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry to establish the India Centre for Lab-grown Diamond Research.

The centre aims to develop domestic expertise in diamond seeds, machinery and manufacturing processes.

To put things into perspective, Table 1 consolidates the results of the 2023 Natural Diamond Council report and a 2020 study by Vladimir Vladimirov et al. to compare attributes of natural and lab-grown diamonds.

The staggering volume in carbon emissions for lab-grown diamonds can be attributed to the energy sources used for production. Diamonds created using coal-heavy power grids have higher carbon emissions, while those manufactured using renewable energy sources have a much lower carbon footprint.

The latter aligns with the United

Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), which emphasise the transition to cleaner energy systems and more sustainable manufacturing practices.

Furthermore, the use of renewable energy in diamond production reflects the principles of a circular economy, where resources are utilised more efficiently and environmental impacts are minimised throughout a product's life cycle.

Although lab-grown diamonds are not entirely free from environmental concerns, the next generation of consumers is increasingly drawn to mined diamonds. This shift in public perception reflects a growing emphasis on ethical sourcing, environmental responsibility, and product traceability.

These advantages become even more significant when one considers the wide range of applications diamonds have in modern society. They are used in heavy-duty industrial processes including cutting and drilling, as well as in quantum computing, protective coatings that extend equipment lifespan, semiconductor manufacturing and several other fields.

For a material so deeply woven into both industry and culture, selecting the more economical and sustainable option becomes no longer a choice – it is a responsibility.

Prof. N. Arunachalam is currently working as a Professor, Department of Mechanical Engineering, and also leading the HPHT technologies development activities for growing diamond in India as part of India Centre for Lab-grown Diamond (IC-LGD). Dr. Vishnuja is working as a Principal Project Scientist at IIT Madras. Dr. U. Vishnuja is working as a Project Manager at IIT Madras. S. Roshnihaasheelan is an IIT Madras MSc student studying at SRIJEE School, Andhra Pradesh.

Table 1 presents a comparison of natural and lab-grown diamonds, drawing on findings from the Natural Diamond Council's 2023 report and a 2020 study by Vladimir Vladimirov et al.

Criteria	Natural diamonds	Lab-grown diamonds
Cost per carat on average	\$13.5-18/ct	\$8,000
Water consumption	6.077 m ³ /ct	0.4-0.02 m ³ /ct
Energy consumption	220 kWh/ct (industrial)	16 kWh/ct (HPHT) 23.47 kWh/ct (CVD)
CO ₂ emissions	100 kg/ct	17-200 kg/ct

Diamond prices vary based on the 4Cs – carat, cut, colour and clarity. The values shown are representative market prices.

Why lab grown diamonds are sustainable alternative to mined stones

What are the Concerns Related to Natural Diamonds

Blood Diamonds (Conflict Diamonds)

Exploitation and Labour Conditions

Environmental Impact:

Large-scale open-pit mines can result in deforestation, soil erosion, and much more.

Major mines like Argyle in Australia and Diavik in Canada are depleting, leading to reduced production.

Why lab grown diamonds are sustainable alternative to mined stones

The Kimberley Process Certification Scheme (KPCS) is an important global initiative established in 2003 to prevent the trade of conflict diamonds from infiltrating the mainstream rough diamond market.

It is enforced individually by KP Participant countries.

The KPCS was established by the United Nations General Assembly Resolution 55/56 following recommendations in the Fowler Report.

Since 2003, India has been actively participating in the KPCS process

The Department of Commerce is the nodal Department, and

Gem & Jewellery Export Promotion Council (GJEPC) is designated as the KPCS Importing and Exporting Authority in India. GJEPC is responsible for issuing KP Certificates and is also the custodian of KP Certificates received in the country.

Why lab grown diamonds are sustainable alternative to mined stones

LGDs are manufactured in laboratories, as opposed to naturally occurring diamonds. However, the chemical composition and other physical and optical properties of the two are the same.

Naturally occurring diamonds take millions of years to form; they are created when carbon deposits buried within the earth are exposed to extreme heat and pressure.

They are mostly manufactured through two processes, High Pressure High Temperature (HPHT) method or Chemical Vapour Deposition (CVD) method.

The environmental footprint of a diamond grown in a laboratory is much lesser than that of a naturally occurring diamond.

Surat: The Hub of Diamond Cutting and Polishing

Surat plays a pivotal role in the global diamond trade. Approximately 90% of the world's diamonds are cut and polished in Surat.

Russia holds what is believed to be the world's largest and richest diamond resources.

Botswana is the leading diamond-producing country in terms of value, and the second largest in terms of volume. Botswana's resources produce the full range of diamonds, in all sizes, colors and clarities.

The problem with India's free trade agreement strategy

The problem with India's free trade agreement strategy

India's trade with key FTA partners such as the ASEAN countries has become increasingly import-driven, resulting in widening trade deficits

DATA POINT

Surendar Singh

Over the past few years, India has shown great interest in trade diplomacy to promote its economic and strategic interests. India's new found enthusiasm in external engagement has culminated in Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) with the UAE, Australia, Oman, the U.K., the European Union, and most recently, New Zealand. Its imperative to enhance market access continues to extend the reach of its trade architecture through ongoing trade talks with the U.S., Gulf countries and Canada, highlighting a decisive shift towards bilateralism as a vehicle of market access, value chain integration and economic dynamism. There is an emerging view among policymakers, trade diplomats, and geopolitical analysts that FTAs are indispensable instruments of economic statecraft. However, the enthusiasm on enhanced market access through trade agreements and Global Value Chain (GVC) integration is founded on a set of implicit assumptions and dominant narratives that continue to maintain a striking analytical silence. The argument that FTAs stimulate export growth and GVC integration runs a far more nuanced view.

Widening trade deficit
India's FTA experience with Asian economies has not been favourable. India's trade with key FTA partners such as the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), South Korea, Japan and Singapore has become increasingly import-driven, resulting in widening trade deficits. Data shows that India's trade deficit with ASEAN increased sharply from \$0.4 billion in 2012 to \$51.2 billion in 2025, driven by rapidly rising imports. In the same manner, imports increased at a much faster pace than exports in the case of Japan and South Korea.

India's trade surplus has turned into a trade deficit in the case of Singapore after signing the trade agreement, exhibiting weakening export competitiveness.

India's export performance across its major Asian FTA partners such as ASEAN, Japan, South Korea and Singapore reveals an intriguing picture – its underperformance. India's share of the import basket among FTA partners has either stagnated or gradually eroded between 2012 to 2025, indicating a weakening in its export competitiveness post-FTAs. The most striking decline is in the case of ASEAN countries where India's share of ASEAN's import basket dropped from 3.42% to 1.71% while in the case of Singapore, the import share declined from 2.27% to 1.71%. Similarly, India's share in South Korea's import basket has declined from 1.33% to 0.93% while its share in Japan's import basket shows mixed trends.

Collectively, these trends indicate that instead of leveraging trade agreements to integrate into regional production networks, India is stuck on the margins of manufacturing-led trade integration. The inability to capitalise on tariff preferences under the FTAs demonstrates that market access based on tariff elimination alone cannot compensate for weak domestic industrial capabilities, logistical inefficiencies, and infrastructure and operational constraints.

India's trade challenge is not fundamentally about negotiating more FTAs but about strengthening domestic productive capabilities and associated impediments. Without adequate industrial transformation, FTAs risk becoming instruments that increase import penetration faster than export competitiveness, thereby widening asymmetrical trade outcomes and structural vulnerabilities.

Moreover, FTAs are often presented as GVC drivers, eliminating barriers to the development of shared production arrangements and industrial upgrading. It is in-

teresting to note that India's GVC integration related to trade as a percentage of gross trade declined from 37.13% to 34.38%, indicating that India's integration in GVC networks has actually weakened. India's GVC trade as a share of gross trade with its FTA partners has declined in the case of South Korea, Japan, Indonesia, Thailand, Vietnam, and Cambodia. Only in the case of Malaysia, Singapore and Philippines, has it increased.

These trends demonstrate that India's FTAs have not translated into broad-based GVC integration. This evidence challenges the conventional assumption that FTAs automatically foster GVC integration through trade liberalisation. Moreover, it raises questions about the proposition that deeper commitments to market access and regulatory harmonisation are, in themselves, sufficient to promote GVC participation. The contemporary policy narrative surrounding India's new FTAs and their ability to integrate into GVCs raises some critical questions.

An assessment

The declining export shares and weakening GVC integration in the case of India's key FTA partners clearly highlight the limitations of considering FTAs primarily as instruments of market access. It is understandable that FTAs may enhance market access in certain product categories, but their abilities to foster productive capabilities is still contested. This essentially means that India's FTA strategy needs to move beyond the standard argument of market access. It should focus on greater interaction with the broader industrial policy framework that emphasises technological upgrading, strategic investment, supply chain realignment, domestic value addition and domestic reforms.

Without such policies, FTAs are likely to remain instruments of trade liberalisation that constrain policy flexibilities rather than drivers of industrial transformation.

Are the FTAs working?

The data for the charts were sourced from the International Trade Centre - Trade Map

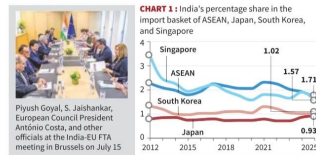


TABLE 1: India's trade with key FTA partners (in \$ billions)

Partner	Indicator	2012	2015	2018	2021	2024	2025
ASEAN	Export	32.3	26.35	36.25	40.68	42.71	35.96
	Import	42.74	41.47	57.51	64.84	81.87	87.19
	Trade balance	-10.44	-15.12	-21.26	-24.16	-39.16	-51.23
Japan	Export	6.4	4.5	4.8	6.1	5.8	6.1
	Import	12.4	9.6	12.6	14.4	18.9	20.9
	Trade balance	-5.95	-5.17	-7.83	-8.34	-13.06	-14.77
South Korea	Export	4.1	3.6	4.3	7.1	6	6
	Import	13.7	13.1	16.4	17.1	20.9	21.1
	Trade balance	-9.6	-9.46	-11.62	-9.97	-14.98	-15.12
Singapore	Export	13.6	7.8	10.5	10.7	15.7	10.7
	Import	7.8	7.4	14.5	18.2	20.5	23.7
	Trade balance	5.76	0.4	-3.99	-7.55	-4.87	-12.97

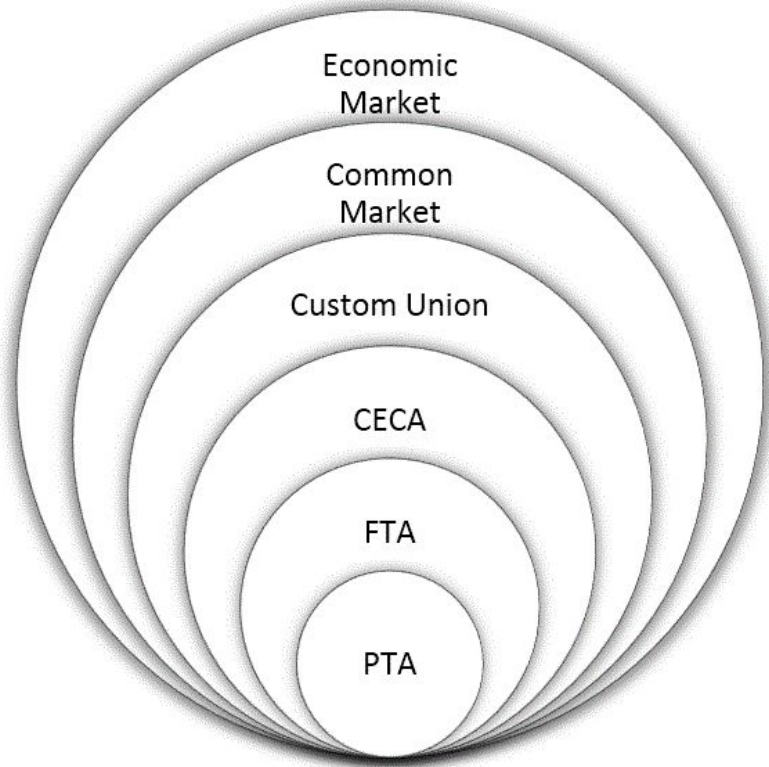
TABLE 2: India's global value chain-related trade as a share of gross trade with Asian FTA partners

	2012	2020	GVC Integration (Increase/Decrease)
Indonesia	41.77	30.1	-11.67
Japan	41.07	28.44	-12.63
Malaysia	49.92	50.26	0.34
South Korea	63.18	41.58	-21.6
Thailand	48.32	47.65	-0.67
Singapore	66.87	69.54	2.67
Philippines	30.47	33.9	3.43
Vietnam	56.89	54.57	-2.32
Cambodia	47.43	44.34	-3.09

The author is an Associate Professor at Jindal School of Liberal Arts and Humanities, O.P. Jindal Global University, Sonapat. Views are personal

The declining share of GVC-related trade in total trade with several major FTA partners shows that preferential market access has been inadequate to bolster India's participation in global production networks. This evidence challenges the conventional assumption that FTAs automatically foster GVC integration through trade liberalisation.

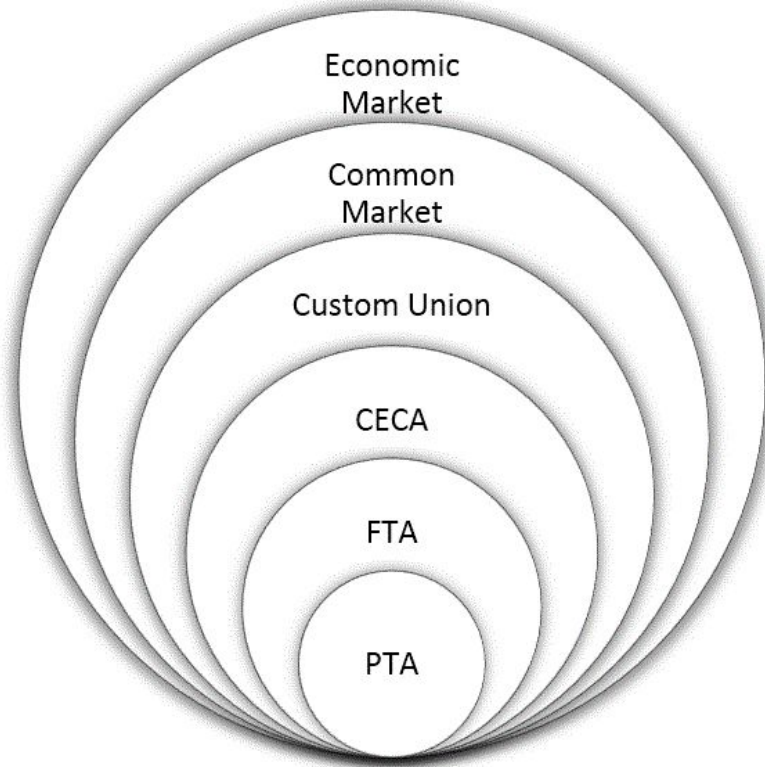
The problem with India's free trade agreement strategy



A preferential trade agreement, is a trading bloc that gives preferential access to certain products from the participating countries. India-Mercosur Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA): Mercosur is a sub-regional blocs with its member countries – full members are Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, Uruguay and Bolivia



The problem with India's free trade agreement strategy



A free-trade area is a trade bloc whose member countries have signed a free-trade agreement (FTA), which eliminates tariffs, import quotas, and preferences on most (if not all) goods and services traded between them.

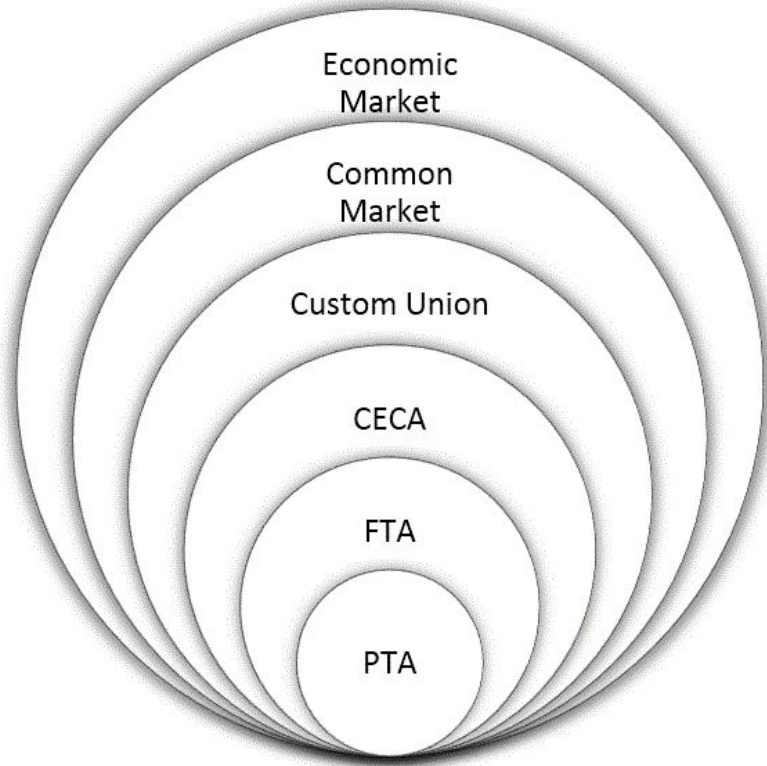
When the countries go beyond FTA and agree for a greater degree of economic integration which includes improving the attractiveness to capital and human resources, and to expand trade and investment, it would result in CECA or CEPA.

CEPA = Comprehensive Economic partnership Agreement

CECA = Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement

CEPA has a bit wider scope than CECA.

The problem with India's free trade agreement strategy



Customs Union

An agreement among countries to have free trade among themselves and to adopt common external barriers against any other country interested in exporting to these countries.

Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) – Its member states are Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates

Common Market

A type of custom union where there are common policies on product regulation, and free movement of goods and services, capital and labour.

Economic and monetary union :

When an union involves unifying currency it becomes a economic and monetary union. Eg – Euro

Critical Minerals, the foundation of strategic power

Critical minerals, the foundation of strategic power

Critical minerals have moved from the margins of resource policy to the centre of industrial strategy and security. Lithium, cobalt, nickel, graphite, copper and rare earth elements are foundational to electric vehicles, storage, renewable power, semiconductors, defence and advanced manufacturing. As decarbonisation and digitalisation accelerate, mineral security is becoming as important as oil once was. The global supply picture is concentrated. For copper, lithium, nickel, cobalt, graphite and rare earth elements, the average market share of the top three refining countries rose to 86% in 2024, from around 82% in 2020. Incremental supply is tied to a few nodes: Indonesia for nickel, and China for cobalt, graphite and rare earths. China is the leading refiner in 19 out of 20 strategic minerals with an average market share of about 70%, making minerals geopolitical, not merely commercial.

Geopolitical risk as a factor

Clean energy transitions will require minerals far beyond today's production systems. The current copper project pipeline points to a potential 30% supply shortfall by 2035. Lithium appears better supplied in the near term but rising demand is expected to drive the market into deficit by the 2030s. Rare earth demand will rise sharply as wind power, electronics and magnets expand.

Geopolitical risk is compounding these pressures. China's rare earth export controls announced in 2025 created concerns across energy, automotive, defence, aerospace, Artificial Intelligence (AI) and semiconductors. Major economies are responding quickly. The European Union (EU) Critical Raw Materials Act sets 2030 benchmarks of 10% domestic extraction, 40% processing and 25% recycling, and no more than 65% from a single country. The United States is diversifying supply chains through partnerships.

India's clean energy and manufacturing ambitions are mineral intensive. Under a net zero scenario, cumulative demand for critical energy



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Critical mineral
security will
define India's
industrial and
strategic
trajectory

transition minerals could reach roughly 169 million tonnes by 2070, about 51% higher than under a current policy pathway. Copper demand will rise with power systems; rare earth demand will grow with wind energy and advanced manufacturing.

India has domestic potential, including reserves of cobalt (44.9 million tonnes), copper (163.9 million tonnes), graphite (211.6 million tonnes) and nickel (189 million tonnes), along with monazite deposits containing rare earth oxides. Recycling could eventually meet up to a quarter of copper and graphite demand by mid-century. Yet, reserves have not ensured supply security. India remains import dependent for lithium, cobalt and nickel, while graphite and China-dominated processing expose it to disruption as demand scales. The critical gap is processing and refining. India's position differs from the EU, the U.S. and Australia, which are building integrated supply chains through mandates, partnerships and processing investments. India is still developing foundational capability. While several minerals are processed domestically, capacity and high-purity production remain constrained. It has bulk-mineral experience but still relies on imports for high-purity critical mineral products.

This is where much value and vulnerability sit. In 2024, China accounted for over 90% of rare earths and graphite processing, nearly 75% of cobalt and 70% of lithium chemicals. India must build midstream capacity to participate meaningfully in supply chain realignment.

Structural constraints

Several constraints slow progress. Exploration remains relatively shallow, regulatory clearances can be time-consuming, private participation is limited and remote-region project economics are challenging. Processing is a larger bottleneck: India lacks some high-purity input facilities, while copper and graphite face smelting, purification and scale constraints. Recycling will play a role

but cannot substitute for primary supply in the near term because feedstock, collection and technology remain limited.

India's policy response since 2023 marks a shift. The government has identified 30 critical minerals, strengthened regulatory frameworks, and launched the **National Critical Mineral Mission** to support the value chain. The mission targets 1,200 domestic exploration projects by 2030-31, production of at least 15 critical minerals, and acquisition of 50 overseas mining assets by Indian companies. The Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL) has secured 15,703 hectares in Argentina's Catamarca province for lithium exploration, while the 2026-27 Budget proposed rare earth corridors in Odisha, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh, and Tamil Nadu. The India-U.S. critical minerals and rare earths framework signed in May 2026 provides an additional diplomatic lever.

Mission to execution

The next phase is execution. Processing and refining must become a national industrial priority, backed by infrastructure and targeted incentives. Private capital needs better geological data, predictable approvals and risk sharing. India should also operationalise strategic stockpiles for critical minerals, accelerate applied research and development through industry partnerships, scale domestic capabilities and diversify overseas supply through trusted partners and platforms.

India energy transition, electronics, semiconductor, defence manufacturing, and advanced industrialisation all depend on secure mineral supplies. While individual policy measures are necessary, they are insufficient. A comprehensive strategy should establish mineral-specific risk thresholds, integrate recycling into supply planning, set measurable milestones, and create a coordinated institutional framework. The priority now is to convert potential into capability and reduce strategic vulnerability through sustained execution.

Critical Minerals, the foundation of strategic power

Definition: Critical minerals are metals and elements that are essential to modern technology and defence but face a high risk of supply disruption due to concentrated production. Lithium, cobalt, nickel, graphite, copper and rare earth elements are the core group.

They are foundational to electric vehicles, battery storage, renewable power, semiconductors, defence systems and advanced manufacturing. As decarbonisation and digitalisation accelerate, mineral security is becoming as strategically important as oil once was.

Critical Minerals, the foundation of strategic power

Rare Earth Minerals

They are a set of seventeen metallic elements. These include the fifteen lanthanides on the periodic table in addition to scandium and yttrium that show similar physical and chemical properties to the lanthanides.

The 17 Rare Earths are cerium (Ce), dysprosium (Dy), erbium (Er), europium (Eu), gadolinium (Gd), holmium (Ho), lanthanum (La), lutetium (Lu), neodymium (Nd), praseodymium (Pr), promethium (Pm), samarium (Sm), scandium (Sc), terbium (Tb), thulium (Tm), ytterbium (Yb), and yttrium (Y).

Critical Minerals, the foundation of strategic power

by Fabio Cramerì via s-ink.org

Critical Minerals, the foundation of strategic power

Refining is concentrated in a few countries: For copper, lithium, nickel, cobalt, graphite and rare earths, the average market share of the top three refining countries rose to 86% in 2024 from around 82% in 2020. Supply now depends on a handful of nodes.

China leads across nearly all strategic minerals: China is the leading refiner in 19 of 20 strategic minerals, with an average market share of about 70%.

The critical gap is processing and refining: India has bulk-mineral experience but relies on imports for high-purity critical mineral products. Capacity and high-purity production remain constrained.

Critical Minerals, the foundation of strategic power

National Critical Mineral Mission: The government has identified 30 critical minerals and launched the Mission to support the value chain, targeting 1,200 domestic exploration projects by 2030-31, production of at least 15 critical minerals, and acquisition of 50 overseas mining assets.

MMDR Act Amendment (2023): Amended the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act to empower the central government to auction mining leases and composite licenses for 24 critical and strategic minerals (like lithium and cobalt).

Overseas acquisition through KABIL: Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL), a joint venture of state-owned firms for overseas mineral assets, has secured acreage in Argentina Catamarca province for lithium exploration.

Domestic rare-earth corridors: The 2026-27 Budget proposed rare-earth corridors in Odisha, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu.

Critical Minerals, the foundation of strategic power

Q. Consider the following statements:

I. India has joined the Minerals Security Partnership as a member.

II. India is a resource-rich country in all the 30 critical minerals that it has identified.

III. The Parliament in 2023 has amended the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957 empowering the Central Government to exclusively auction mining lease and composite license for certain critical minerals.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

[A] I and II only

[B] II and III only

[C] I and III only

[D] I, II and III

Thank You